

How Much Do Audience and Format Actually Change the Output?

An empirical A/B test on the Writing Workspace. We took one finished run — the land-value-tax-for-New-Zealand essay — and regenerated it twice, each time changing exactly one dial, so the effect of each lever can be measured rather than asserted.

The experiment

Three pieces, same topic, same facts, same argument spine. Everything that could be held constant was held constant — the research (factsheet.md's fifteen F-tags), the provocation dial (low), the visuals dial (auto), the deliverables D1–D4. Only one lever moves per variant:

	Audience	Format	Lever changed
A — baseline	general	essay	— (control)
B	socialist	essay	audience only
C	general	op-ed	format only

Because the facts are fixed and only one input moves at a time, every difference between A and B is attributable to **audience**, and every difference between A and C to **format**. The drafts themselves sit beside this file (variant-B-socialist-essay.md, variant-C-general-oped.md); the baseline is the run's own final.md.

The measurements

Dimension	A — general / essay	B — socialist / essay	C — general / op-ed
Lever vs A	baseline	audience only	format only
Word count	1,605	1,611	898
Length band	1,400–1,700	1,400–1,700	700–900
Section headings (H2)	7	5	0
Structure	8-beat essay	8-beat essay	op-ed: news-peg lede → 3 fast reasons → objection → kicker
Facts used (of 15)	15	15	13 (drops F9 TWG, F15 intl deferral)
Visuals	1 bar chart	1 bar chart	0 (format veto)
Controlling metaphor	"the corner that got lucky"	the tollkeeper on socially-made rent	"the corner that got lucky"
Imagery domain	neighbourhood / property / local infrastructure	labour / commons / ground rent / enclosure	neighbourhood / property / local infrastructure
Voice	3rd person, explanatory	3rd person, systemic + solidary	1st person, columnist
Register markers	plain; every term defined	"ground rent", "unearned", "accumulation", "rentier", "settlement", "class"	"I'll put my conclusion first"; news peg; biting kicker
Assumed knowledge	new to the topic	knows class / why markets concentrate wealth — not re-explained	new to the topic
Provocation (dial held)	low	low	low

What the audience lever did (A → B)

Holding the format fixed, swapping `general` for `socialist` changed **almost nothing structural and almost everything on the surface**:

- **Length: unchanged** (1,605 → 1,611, +0.4%). **Facts used: unchanged** (15 → 15). **Visuals: unchanged** (the chart stays). **Spine: unchanged** (same eight beats, same steelman→reply).
- **Imagery domain: ~100% turnover**. The neighbourly "corner that got lucky" becomes the rentier "tollkeeper at a bridge he did not build"; the metaphor field moves from property-and-traffic to commons-rent-and-enclosure, exactly the worlds the two audience files license (`general.md` §4 vs `socialist.md` §4).
- **Register and vocabulary changed wholesale** — "ground rent", "the unearned increment", "accumulation", "a settlement, not an accident".
- **What gets explained changed**. B never explains why money concentrates in land — the socialist profile's §3 forbids re-teaching that — and spends the saved room on the political-economy reading instead. The respect floor moved.

What the format lever did (A → C)

Holding the audience fixed, swapping `essay` for `op-ed` changed **the entire scaffold and left the voice's world intact**:

- **Length: -44%** (1,605 → 898), tracking the band (1,400–1,700 → 700–900).
- **Headings: 7 → 0**. The op-ed runs as continuous column prose; the essay's section architecture disappears.
- **Structure rebuilt** to the op-ed contract — a news peg (Wellington's 2024 rates debate), thesis in the first 120 words, three compressed reasons, one objection beat, and a kicker instead of a payoff section.
- **Visuals: 1 → 0**. The affordability chart vanishes — not by choice but because the op-ed format vetoes visuals unless the brief forces them (`oped.md` §5). This is the cleanest single proof that visuals are a *format* outcome: identical audience and identical visuals: auto dial, opposite result.
- **Facts: 15 → 13**. The word budget forced two facts out (the Tax Working Group note, the international-deferral precedent) — the spine survives, the supporting detail is what gets cut.
- **Imagery domain: unchanged**. C keeps A's "lucky corner" and its neighbourhood vocabulary exactly, because the audience didn't move.

The same beat, three ways

The opening — all carrying the identical fact (F4: land value is community-made):

A (general/essay): "A house in a New Zealand suburb is worth more this winter than it was last, and the family inside it did nothing to earn the difference."

B (socialist/essay): "When a train line opens in a New Zealand suburb, the land beside it gets richer overnight. Not the workers who laid the track ... the person who owns the dirt."

C (general/op-ed): "When Wellington City Council floated the idea, in 2024, of shifting its rates onto the value of land ... it was the most sensible tax idea a New Zealand council has put on the table in years."

Same fact, three doors: a neighbour's window (A), an owner-versus-labour ledger (B), a news peg (C).

Verdict

The two levers act on different layers, and the magnitudes are not symmetric:

- **Format is the structural lever.** It set length (−44%), rebuilt the structure, erased the section headings (7 → 0), removed the visual (1 → 0), and forced a fact cut (−13%) — while leaving the imagery domain and the audience-facing voice essentially untouched.
- **Audience is the surface lever.** It left length, fact count, spine, and visuals identical, then turned over the imagery domain (~100%), the register and vocabulary, and the contract of what may be assumed and what must be explained.

Put plainly: **format decides the shape of the container; audience decides the texture of what's poured in.** Change the format and you get a differently-sized, differently-built artifact carrying fewer or more of the same facts. Change the audience and you get the same artifact, re-voiced for a different reader. A brief that gets either dial wrong fails in a different way — the wrong format ships the wrong *object*; the wrong audience ships the right object to the wrong *person*.